

## Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist_main.tex`).

The official IST journal policy confirms a **15,000-word maximum for research papers**. The current author guidance supplied with this revision additionally assigns **200 words to each figure or table** and counts references and manuscript appendices. This declaration uses a deliberately conservative implementation of that rule.

| Component                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Seven body sections ( <code>texcount</code> sum, including section headings and caption text encountered in those files)   |
| Structured abstract ( <code>texcount</code> sum)                                                                           |
| Remaining front matter and required declarations (title/keywords, CRediT, competing interest, data availability statement) |
| Main-text tables and figures ( $7 \times 200$ )                                                                            |
| Rendered reference list (65 entries; conservative <code>pdftotext</code> count including the heading and page folios)      |
| <b>Conservative IST submission equivalent</b>                                                                              |

The controlling total is therefore **13,859 words**, leaving **1,141 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word limit. The structured abstract contains 222 prose words (227 under the `texcount` sum convention), below 300 words.

This total is intentionally stricter than a research-content-only count. It includes all required declaration text even though such text is commonly treated as submission metadata. It also retains caption words already encountered by `texcount` and then assigns the full 200-word allowance to every rendered float, so it does not undercount captions. The paper has no manuscript appendices. The separately submitted `supplement.pdf` is online supplementary material, not an appendix embedded in the research paper.

Reproduction commands:

```
sh cd paper/ist texcount -sum -brief ../sections/introduction.tex ../sections/related_work.tex
../sections/methodology.tex ../sections/results.tex ../sections/discussion.tex ../sections/th
../sections/conclusion.tex sed -n "43,68p" ist_main.tex | texcount -sum -brief - texcount
-inc -sum ist_main.tex rg -c "^\\{\\}bibitem" ist_main.bbl rg -F "\\{\\}@writefile{lot}"
ist_main.aux rg -F "\\{\\}@writefile{lof}" ist_main.aux pdftotext ist_main.pdf - |
sed -n "/^References$/, $p" | wc -w
```

Count date: 26 July 2026. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.